
Coping With Microaggressions

Understand, absorb, respond, protect yourself

4 psychology approaches · tips — by EvaTalk

TO BEGIN

Understand, absorb, respond, protect yourself

A 'harmless' remark, an ambiguous compliment, a misplaced question: microaggressions are those small repeated wounds that, added up, wear you down. What you feel is real.

This guide helps you understand what's happening, not internalize it, choose if and how to respond, and protect yourself.

YOUR INTENTION

A microaggression that recurs or stayed with you: _____

What microaggressions are

Often unintentional, but with a very real impact: their force comes from repetition ('a thousand small cuts') and ambiguity, which sows doubt ('did I imagine it?').

Feeling their weight isn't being 'too sensitive': it's a normal reaction to repeated aggression.

Example

Hearing 'you speak so well!' over and over, Aïcha felt reduced to an exception — and saw her discomfort was legitimate.

Name it

Describe a microaggression you lived, and the emotion it left.

Validate

Write: 'My feeling is legitimate — the ambiguity doesn't erase it.'

Takeaway — It's not being 'too sensitive' — it's a normal reaction.

Doubt and rumination

Afterward the mind spins: 'I overreacted', 'I should have responded', 'I'm the problem'. These thoughts internalize the aggression.

Reframing them puts responsibility where it belongs: on the aggression, not on you.

Example

Léa blamed herself for staying silent for days. Understanding that freezing is normal freed her from guilt.

Out of rumination

Note the looping thought · a fairer answer ('the problem is the aggression').

Don't internalize

Write: 'This message about me is false — I return it to sender.'

Takeaway — The problem is the aggression — not your sensitivity.

Respond, or not

You owe no response, and no teaching. Choosing your battles and preserving your energy is a right, not cowardice.

If you choose to respond: name the fact, ask a question ('what do you mean?'), or set a limit — without having to justify yourself.

Example

Depending on the day, Nia responds or lets it go. Deciding consciously, rather than enduring, gave her back power.

My choice

For next time: respond or preserve my energy? Both are legitimate.

A ready line

Prepare a short line in case you choose to respond: _____

Takeaway — You owe no response or teaching — choose your battles.

Protect yourself & surround yourself

Support (loved ones, community, spaces where you have nothing to prove) protects against wear. Reducing exposure when possible and caring for yourself aren't retreat, but strategy.

If it's repeated or serious (especially at work), it's worth taking higher (HR, management).

Example

By surrounding herself with people who 'get it without her explaining', Fatou felt the weight lift.

My resource spaces

Where / with whom do you have nothing to prove? How to spend more time there?

Escalate if needed

If repeated at work: what step (HR, in writing, a witness)? _____

Takeaway — Protecting and surrounding yourself isn't retreat — it's strategy.

Key takeaways

- Feeling the weight of microaggressions isn't being 'too sensitive'.
- The problem is the aggression — not you: don't internalize it.
- You owe no response or teaching — choose your battles.
- If you respond: name, question, or set a limit, without justifying.
- Surround yourself with spaces where you have nothing to prove.
- If repeated or serious (work), take it higher (HR).

Your turn

My experience

The microaggression	My legitimate feeling

My strategy

Respond / preserve	My resource space

YOUR JOURNEY

Your 4-week plan

Week 1

Name and validate my feeling.

Week 2

Step out of rumination.

Week 3

Decide on my responses.

Week 4

Strengthen my resource spaces.

YOUR PLAN

Your action plan

My 'the problem is the aggression' line:

My ready line (if I respond):

My resource space:

The problem is the aggression — not you. You have the right to protect yourself.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool — not therapy. If you're going through a very hard time, reach out to a crisis line in your country. Therapy can help a lot. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.